What Remains: My Family Memory and the Ethiopian Red Terror

He survived prison, but he never told me what happened!

The Ethiopia Red Terror took place 1976-1978 and was accompanied by widespread arrests, torture and mass killing of those perceived as political opponent. It's a history that remains relatively marginal in global transitional justice discourse and a contested memory in Ethiopia. For families like mine, these wider struggles over memory intersect with personal silences, fragmented recollections, and stories that were never fully told.

My father was imprisoned from 1975 to 1977 during Ethiopia's Derg regime. He rarely spoke about his experience, leaving me with little understanding of what he experienced. Bridget Conley, in *Memory from the Margins: The Red Terror Martyrs Memorial Museum in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia*, describes how survivors of the Red Terror could build a "wall around their memories." This description resonates with my father's silence.



The person behind the memory: my beloved father, Matiyas Mulugeta

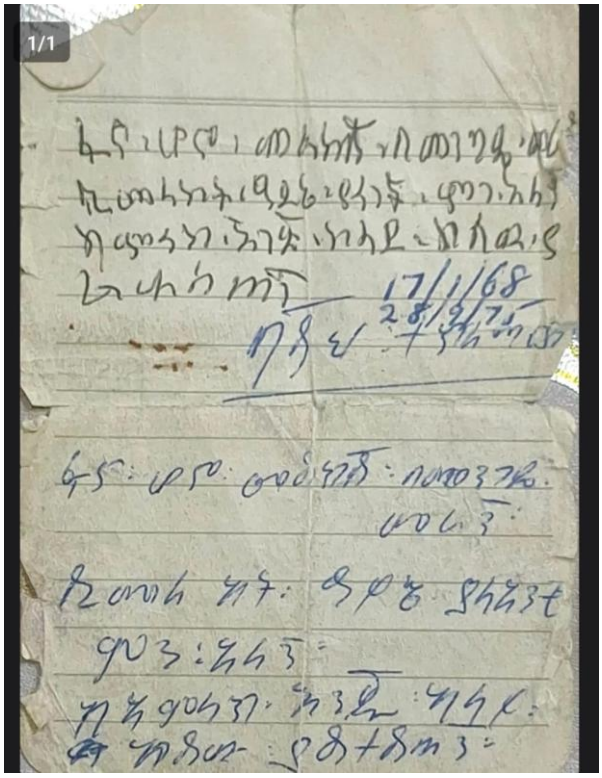
One surviving traces is a pair of socks my father made while imprisoned. Other prisoners were making socks, and he asked them to teach him, partly to occupy his mind. He asked my mother to bring him the thin metal from inside an umbrella, which he filed and sharpened to make them. The socks are ordinary objects, but their making records an extraordinary situation: imprisonment, scarcity and the prisoners' ability to create with the limited materials.



The socks my father made while in prison

My mother remembers that my father continued to wear them after he was released from prison. As an adult, I would sometimes massage my father's feet. He would tell me to be gentle because his feet were sensitive, and he told me that this was because of the beatings he had received. Amnesty International's 1978 report, *Human Rights Violations in Ethiopia*, documented the torture of political detainees under the Derg, including beatings of the soles of the feet**.** The socks therefore became more than objects made during his imprisonment: they carried a memory of that experience into his life after release. For me, they now hold a trace of my father's past, connecting an ordinary object to the violence his body remembered.

The next object is a poem my father gave my mother. They were not yet married. My mother had written him a birthday poem, and he wanted to return the gesture. As shown on the poem, Bashahe Tiklemariam, a fellow prisoner, initially wrote it down for him, while later my father copied it in his own handwriting. My mother recalls, my father later took the poem back from her to refine it. Eventually, it remained in his wallet until his death.



The poem he kept in his wallet, written in 1975

My translation:

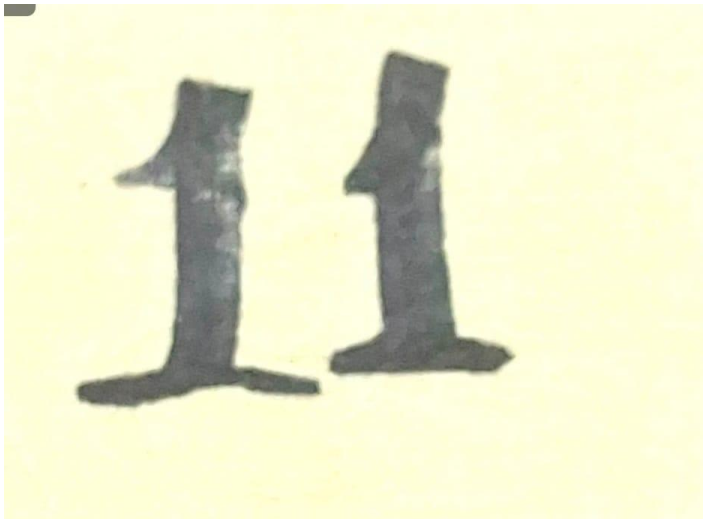
Your face is the light that guides my path.

When my eye looks upon you, I have nothing but you.

It was God from above, not any human being, who gave you to me.

My mother remembers receiving it with great happiness. Looking back now, she says that he was right: she was his light, and he was her pillar. For her, the poem expresses hope and comfort and reflects the relationship they shared. For me, it preserves a glimpse of my father beyond his imprisonment; a personal memory of love and the life he continued to hold onto.

Another fragment is the memory of Room No. 11 at Kerchele Prison, also known as Alem Bekagn, meaning "Farewell to the World", where my father was imprisoned. It was a major detention site in Addis Ababa during the Derg period and the Red Terror. When people came to visit him, my father was called from Room No. 11, and when he was released from prison, he brought the number "11" with him. I did not know that this number existed, or the story behind it, until my mother sent me the photograph. For me, the photograph and the number became a newly recovered piece of family memory; a material trace connecting me to a place that had shaped my father's experience but that I had never known about.



Room No. 11: *The number my father carried with him after his release.*

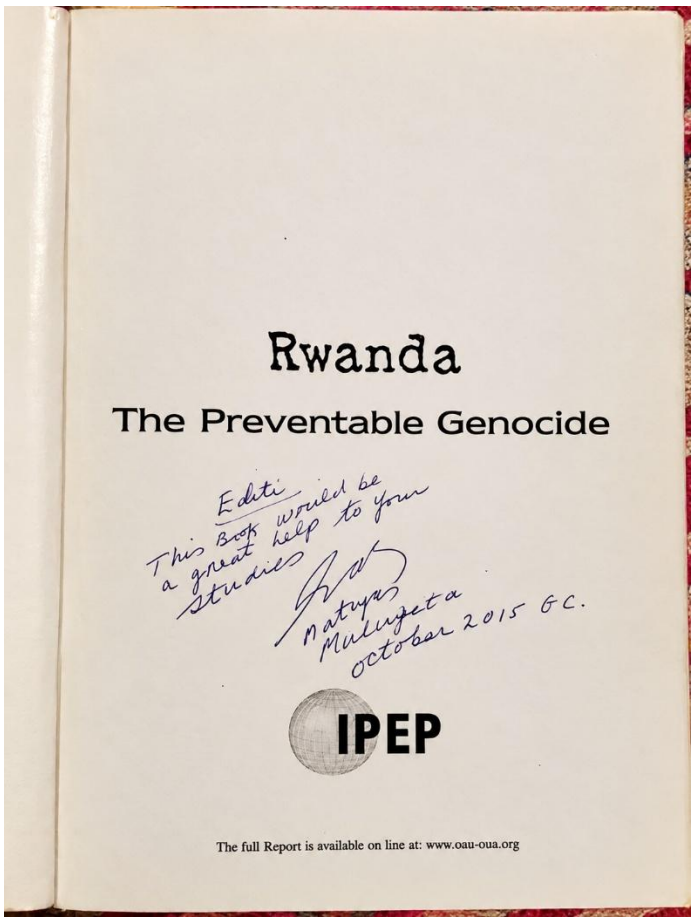
Another object has disappeared: an embroidery. During one of my mother's Sunday prison visits, my father gave her an embroidered piece showing her carrying a pot on her head. She remembers its bright colours and the craftsmanship and how difficult it was to see a young man with such creativity confined as a political prisoner.

The embroidery remained in my parents' bedroom for years before being lost. My mother still hopes it will be found. My sister and I also remember how beautiful it was. There is no photograph of it, making its absence itself part of our family archive, a reminder that archives are shaped not only by what survives, but also by what is lost.



In the absence of the embroidery: My mother who inspired it

Another object connects my father's experience to my own intellectual journey: a book he brought specifically for me, *Rwanda: The Preventable Genocide*. The book concerns mass human-rights violations in Rwanda, a history different from the violence my father experienced in Ethiopia, but one that speaks to the broader questions of violence, memory and accountability. Years later, I began researching transitional justice, Red Terror, memory and how societies deal with violent pasts. The book has become part of my family archive and a personal connection between my father's experience of political imprisonment and the questions I would later come to investigate.



A book gifted by my dad

My father is no longer here to tell his story, but his memory survives in objects, in my mother's recollections, in my sibling's memory, and in my own attempts to understand what I was never fully told. This raises the question at the heart of *Who Owns Memory?* when the person who lived through an experience is gone, who carries the responsibility for remembering it, and who has the right to tell it? I did not inherit my father's complete story. I inherited its traces. Some remain, some lost, and some perhaps never to be recovered. Yet through these fragments, his memory continues to move between people, objects and generations.

With all my love,

Eden Matiyas Mulugeta